



Planet melting warning

Climate scientists reported that recently a chunk of sea ice the size of India melted near Antarctica. <http://dgit.in/iceIndiamlt>



1.9 MP action camera

Casio announces a new rugged action camera specifically designed to be used in the dark. <http://dgit.in/CasioNcam>

Origins

nook

CHAPTER 2 - OCR - THE EBOOK SUPERCHARGER

While Project Gutenberg was started with the best intentions, the initial output was slow due to the process being followed - each book would be typed in manually by Michael or a volunteer. It reached it's 10th ebook in 1989 with the King James Bible. Around this time, Optical Character Recognition (OCR) was sufficiently advanced to directly speed up the ebook creation process. Companies like ABBYY make OCR accessible to general public. And as the volumes increased, more people joined the efforts of Hart to take Project Gutenberg forward.

BACKSTORY 1 - OCR

Basic OCR technology was being used as early as 1914. Yes, even handheld versions. We are talking about the Optophone here, a device built for the sightless, that could scan the letters on a paper and produce a corresponding tone which the listener would be trained to identify. Initial speeds were around one word per minute but this went up to 19-20 words a minute by the 1920s. The time period from 1970 to 1990 can be said to have truly brought OCR to the forefront of digitizing the written word, with significant developments like the first commercial handheld OCR scanner from the Caere Corporation, omnifont recognition from Kurzweil Computer Products Inc. and similar products from ABBYY.

CHAPTER 3 - THE INTERACTABLE BOOK

Much before electronic books had been perfected, some part of the interest in the field had moved towards creating and experiencing interactive books - books where the user could interact with the flow of the story. And even here there is some general misconception regarding the first. Eastgate Systems' 'Afternoon', written by Michael Joyce and released in 1987 on the floppy disk, is widely named as the first hypertext fiction and often confused to be the first interactive book, where, in fact, there have been multiple examples in the same decade. A popular one was The Hobbit (1982) where the user progressed the story by typing instructions into it, although it can be argued that this was more of a game than a book.

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